

Q How can I help my baby adjust to a new child-care arrangement?

Make sure that you have chosen a caregiver that you are happy with, so that you can be as relaxed as possible. Your baby will pick up on your anxieties.

Give your baby plenty of time to get used to the new person and routine and try to start the settling in process well before—preferably a few weeks—you go back to work. Babies are far more adaptable than we give them credit for and, with time and patience, can get used to any new arrangements. Initially, it is helpful for

you and your baby to spend time with the new caregiver before introducing short periods of time when he is alone with the caregiver. Gradually build up the time he spends away from you with the caregiver so that by the time you go back to work you are all used to the situation and he is completely happy to be left.



Gentle hello Be as relaxed as possible when introducing your child to a new caregiver.

SETTLING IN TIPS

Here are a few pointers to make the transition easier for you and your child:

» **Keep calm:** however anxious you might feel about leaving your baby, try to be as relaxed as you can; your baby will pick up on any nerves. Think positive!

» **Home visit:** your baby probably feels more relaxed and confident in his own surroundings so it can be useful for a babysitter, or staff member from the day-care center you are considering to visit you at home in order for you both to get to know each other better.

» **Take a toy:** it can be helpful for your baby to have something familiar with him, such as a favorite toy or comfort object.

» **Keep it brief:** try to make a clean break when you say goodbye to your baby, even if he cries. However upsetting this can be, if you go back to him repeatedly it may simply prolong his distress (and therefore yours). Most babies are easily distracted once you have gone. You could ask the caregiver to call you later to let you know that he has happily settled down.

» **Communicate:** while this is a challenging new experience for you and your baby, your caregiver has probably been through this many times. Share any worries and concerns that you have. Your caregiver will want to listen and talk through how best to deal with any distress that you or your baby is experiencing. Remember that you are all working toward the same goal: a happy baby.

Q I'm worried about putting my baby into child care. Will he miss me or will he love his caregiver more than me?

Rest assured that your baby will benefit from forming new relationships with different adults who he will indeed form a strong bond with and grow to love—but this doesn't mean that he will love you any less. Leaving your precious baby with a caregiver can cause a whole range of emotions from guilt to sadness, not to mention some relief that you have a little time to yourself. He will be thrilled to see you each time you pick him up and you will cherish these moments. Your baby has more than enough love for you, his family, and his caregivers.

Q The future feels unknown, but very exciting! How should I deal with not knowing what lies ahead?

Parenting constantly presents new challenges, and just when you think you've got the hang of things, your child reaches a new developmental stage, and you need to catch up. Deciding the right work/life balance and choosing child care are big decisions. At times, being a parent can seem terrifying—will you be able to do the very best for your child, and will he be happy and fulfilled? There aren't many things you can do in life that have such a profound effect on you as when you become a parent. However, the best way of managing is to try to be as organized as

possible, to enjoy your child, and to be as flexible as you can. Things can and will change. Highs and lows can be intense (not helped by exhaustion in the early years), but mostly, becoming a parent is pretty exhilarating because you experience a totally new and heart-stopping kind of love, and feel a renewed sense of purpose.

The more people who take care of your baby, and that he forms lasting bonds with, the more loving he will become himself.